

Preface

It is with hope and pride that we present to you a guidebook to Poland's most renowned and respected wall. With pride, as the quality of the climbs has passed the test of time and proved that Kazalnica is worth every word of its myth. And with hope, as we would like to see more climbers, especially from abroad, discovering the beauty and the class of this truly unique face.

What have you climbed on Kazalnica in winter?—is the basic question which every generation of climbers uses as a reference. Tell me what you have done there and I'll tell you who you are. Both in summer and winter the climbs on Kazalnica and the Cwm are a benchmark for serious adventure. Some think of her with fear, some with affection, but all share the same respect.

Although not very high—only 450 m—the wall is quite intimidating. Grey and red slabs, no clear leading formations, lines of huge overhangs and an obvious steepness—all this makes Kazalnica look very serious. On top of that, objective dangers, problems with retreat and quite often less than adequate protection with only a few in-situ bolts—make many climbers think twice before they take up a climb. Still, it is not the role of this guidebook to discourage anybody. To the contrary—we readily recommend climbing Kazalnica and discover its values for yourself. The reason we believe you will enjoy it is the truly unique experience which this face provides. The beauty of the lines, some of them true masterpieces, the exposure, the breathtaking view of walls and tarns and the technical and mental involvement—they are all elements of the finest nature comprising the all regard as Alpinism.

Most of the history of Polish climbing is intimately connected with Kazalnica and Cwm. All the best and the greatest had put their names on the ascent list: Długosz, Momatiuk, Kurczab, Heinrich, Chrobak, Piotrowski, Kukuczka, Kurtyka—to mention just a few. The major breakthroughs took place there: the first ascent of a wall (the Łapiński and Paszucha route), the first ascent of center of the crag (Długosz' route), epics of the conquest of the central Pillar, the winter ascent of the Chrobak route in 1968, later the free-climbing revolution finalised with the victory over the Great Roof (X-) and today the winter free-climbing movement.

The striking walls of Kazalnica constantly enchant climbers of every generation. Inevitably, every Tatra climber has to take up its shadowed challenge—some to tick it out, some to return for more. We hope this little work helps you find your own way. Enjoy...